

Guidelines for implementing syndromic surveillance in Europe and proposal for a European syndromic surveillance strategy

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The Triple-S project (Syndromic Surveillance Systems, assessment toward guidelines for Europe) was launched in 2010 for a 3-year period. Coordinated by the French Institute for Public Health Surveillance (InVS), it involved 24 organisations from 13 countries.

The objectives of the project were to review and analyse syndromic surveillance (SyS) activities across Europe as basis for developing guidelines to support the implementation of SyS systems in Europe Union Member States (MS), and to propose a European strategy for SyS.

The guidelines provide evidence-based practical recommendations and suggestions for designing, implementing and improving SyS systems and include examples of past and on-going initiatives from some European countries. The guidelines describe minimum requirements for developing SyS systems and reporting findings in Europe. They aim to encourage a common understanding of the structure and utility of SyS systems across Europe, and to improve communication among MS on critical public health threats.

The project's next step was to suggest a proposal for a European SyS strategy. The proposal is based on discussions and consensus reached by the Triple-S consortium, the output of the review of SyS activities in Europe, and on the results of a semi-standardised survey among actual and potential SyS system users in Europe. The proposal highlights the usefulness of SyS for various purposes from detection of unexpected events to risk assessment during potentially health threatening events. It discusses three possible models for different levels of standardization of SyS across Europe, depending on the purpose and the monitored syndrome, and makes recommendations for enhancing comparability of SyS systems in Europe. Lastly, the proposal identifies synergies between SyS systems and existing surveillance systems and projects, involving different national, European and international players.